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# Flip Phillips

*Tenor saxophonist Joseph "Flip" Phillips is a featured artist at many jazz festivals across the country. A native of Brooklyn, he was born in 1915 and was playing clarinet in local clubs by the age of 19. In 1942, Flip added the tenor sax and was soon hired by Benny Goodman and Red Norvo. He became a prominent soloist in one of Woody Herman's early "herds." His bandmates included Chubby Jackson, Dave Tough and Bill Harris. Flip became a mainstay of Norman Granz's Jazz at the Philharmonic Tours and in 1947 he recorded the memorable solo on "Perdido" that led to a million selling record. During his career, he has been teamed with other jazz legends of the tenor sax, including Illinois Jacquet and Lester Young, who often called on Flip to repair his horn.*

*Flip Phillips was interviewed at the Sarasota Jazz Festival on April 11, 1996 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.*

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. My name is Monk Rowe and it's a great pleasure to have with us saxophonist Flip Phillips. And I have to ask you what it's like to play with all these friends at this festival and it's interesting to stand back stage and watch everybody come in and greet their friends.

FP: Are you talking about Wednesday night? Yeah. That was quite a thrill for me because I haven't seen some of these fellows in years. And I think it was the oldest band I ever played with.

MR: There is a lot of years on stage.

FP: Oh, yeah. And it was great to see everybody you know, and literally to see them. Because a lot of them aren't here now, and it was great. I really enjoyed it you know.

MR: Well you've had quite a career as a musician, would you do it all over again?

FP: Oh, yeah. I had a great life, a wonderful life. It's hard times, good times, but all-in-all everything was great.

MR: I've read something about your career, you started on clarinet?

FP: Yeah. That was my first instrument. My cousin, Frank Reed, who was an excellent musician, was a saxophone player and clarinet. And I sort of looked up to him and he bought me this clarinet for ten dollars you know, in 1927. And it was just wonderful. I started on that and he told me if you want to play the saxophone, start on the clarinet because that's a good foundation for you and the saxophone will come easier to you, which it did you know. The clarinet is a little more intricate and you have to close the holes and the saxophone has buttons and it was a good thing. If anybody is starting play would start on clarinet first.

MR: Good advice. When was your first, do you remember your first professional engagement?

FP: Well yeah. I had the clarinet about two weeks. And I went on my first job. I got a dollar and a half. And I wasn't thinking about that, I just wanted to play that's all.

MR: And this was in Brooklyn?

FP: In Brooklyn, yeah. 1927. That was a good year you know. That was the year Babe Ruth hit 60 home runs and Lindbergh crossed the Atlantic. That's when I started.

MR: And you started on the clarinet. A very good year indeed.

FP: It was a good year.

MR: Tell me about Schneider's Lobster House. Was this a place you played for a while?

FP: Schneider's Lobster House was in Brooklyn and it was right near St. John's college, they had a great basketball team and a great baseball team, and that was in 1934 I think, or '35. And all the young kids that went to college used to come in to Schneider's. It was swing-ing. It was a swinging club you know, in Brooklyn. All the college kids from St. John's, they used to come in to Schneider's Lobster House. And those years were the dipsy doodle and the lindy hop and all of that. The place was swinging, it was a good place.

MR: The music, the jazz at the time, was it moving from Dixieland to swing? Was it kind of in the middle or can you describe it all?

FP: Well it was swinging in those days, like I remember Benny Goodman was just starting out you know. He had the band at Billy Rose in New York. He wasn't very popular yet you know, but he was a good player, and he had good bands and everything. But he wasn't that popular until he made that tour to California. And there were a lot of good players.

MR: When you moved to tenor sax —

FP: Well I played with Frankie Newton in 1939, I was still playing clarinet. We opened Kelly's Stables in New York. And those were swinging, like Pete Brown and Frankie, Eddie Doggerty on drums, Harry Prates on the bass and Ram Ramirez on piano. It was a swinging club. Everybody used to come in to the club. That's when Coleman Hawkins came back from Europe in 1939 and '40. We opened it in 1940. In 1939 it was on 51st Street, and in 1940 he opened on 52nd Street, and we were the main band. And Nat King Cole was the relief trio.

MR: Not bad relief.

FP: And Slim and Slam was the other relief. Art Tatum used to play the off night. It was just wonderful.

MR: Wow. That was a happening scene, 52nd Street, at that time?

FP: Oh, it was the swinginest street in the United States. Everybody was there.

MR: When you were first learning the tenor, did you have someone you wanted to sound like at that time?

FP: Well I played alto before the tenor, and the first guy I ever listed to was Frankie Trumbauer. That was in 1927. He made that record at Vic's, "Singing the Blues" and I heard him play that and I says wow, he is good, he knows how to play the intervals you know. He was wonderful. And that's the first guy I ever heard. Then I heard everybody else, but he was the first guy that influenced me, that made something with me. In those days they had Andy Sannella and Rudy Wiedoft and different saxophone players, but this guy, Frankie Trumbauer, could really play the saxophone. And I says that's it.

MR: Wasn't there, some of those guys were almost doing like this semi-classical saxophone, like Rudy—

FP: They were doing slap tonguing, "Flight of the Bumble Bee" and all that. Frankie played good. Good sound, good intervals, and he swung too. He was the first guy.

MR: So from the time you were in your early twenties, you said I'm going to be a musician, this is my career?

FP: Oh, yeah. I liked it you know. You've got to like it to do it, and I stayed with it. I loved it. I'd rather play than eat. I used to play and my mother used to call me to come and, "Just a minute, just a minute" you know. And I'd play with everybody. I'd be sitting in here or there. I loved it.

MR: Great. How did the first time with Woody Herman come about?

FP: The first time with Woody Herman. I was with Russ Morgan before that. No I was with Red Norvo. And Ralph Burns was the piano player, and I went with Russ Morgan and Ralph went with Charlie Barnet and then he went with Woody, and Ralph told Woody about me. You know and I didn't want to leave Russ Morgan. It was a nice job and all that. But he said he'd write the book around me and all that. And I says okay, so I went with Woody.

MR: Were you "Flip" then? Did you get that nickname before?

FP: Yeah, I got it long before that.

MR: It had to be a long time.

FP: A long time ago.

MR: It kind of stuck with you I guess.

FP: Yeah.

MR: Now you and Bill Harris were quite a team.

FP: Oh — he was my partner. He was great. Play any which way you want you know. Play as soulful as a — or lagging, or fighting, shout, a lovely ballad, he'd play it any way, any mood you'd get in, he was there. He was a good player.

MR: And this group played mostly for dances — Woody Herman's group?

FP: Woody Herman?

MR: Yeah.

FP: Well we used to play all the one-nighters you know, they'd all dance. Most of them used to stand in front of the band and watch us you know. That's how the concerts came about. They saw all these people standing in front, why not get seats and play for them? That's the way it came about. But we used to play these big auditoriums, big ballrooms you know, and half of the people in front were listening to the band, the other people are dancing in the back. And they got the idea to sell tickets, years ago.

MR: What was it like getting to see the country at that point?

FP: Oh, it was wonderful. It was a little tougher than it is today to travel you know, because we had one road to get into the town, it was an asphalt road, that was the only way you could get in, one way. Now they've got the superhighways and planes and all we had was buses. And some of them used to break down. And they didn't have these McDonald's or Burger Kings, they had nothing. Sometimes you had no place to eat. You'd have to stock up, if you were making a trip at night. But I was younger and it was fun. We had some great nights playing. And it was all worth it.

MR: You were doing what you wanted to.

FP: Huh?

MR: You were doing what you liked?

FP: Oh, yeah. It was great. We had some great times.

MR: And Norman Granz picked you out for the Jazz at the Philharmonic.

FP: Yeah. That's after the big bands started to break up. Woody broke up in 1946, and I joined. Norman called me and I came in in 1946 in September we started. At the beginning he just toured on the West Coast in '44 or '45, he never went cross country. In '46 he started to go all over the United States you know, and that was the first time he went out. And I was with him for eleven years, until 1957.

MR: Who else was on the tour? I know there was a lot of different people.

FP: At the beginning, oh, at the very beginning we had everybody. He put together the best in jazz, the best in music, the best players. He was the only man that I know that could do a thing like that, to assemble a group like that. Well you had, your tenor saxophones was Coleman Hawkins, Lester Young, Ben Webster, Illinois Jacquet, Stan Getz, Sonny Stitt — I hope I don't leave anybody out — all the best. On the trumpets he had Roy Eldridge, Charlie Shavers, Dizzy Gillespie, Sweets, Fats Navarro, all the best in jazz. Any section. The rhythm section you had the best. Hank Jones, Oscar Peterson, Buddy Rich, Louis Bellson, Jo Jones, Gene Krupa.

MR: Wow.

FP: Nobody could do that but Norman Granz. And he should be well honored for that you know, the best. As far as singers he had Ella Fitzgerald, Billie Holiday, Sarah Vaughan, Helen Humes, the best. The best in the world. And I don't know of anybody else that

could do that. That was the highlights of everybody's life for heaven's sake. It was mine. The alto players were the best, Charlie Parker, Benny Carter, Johnny Hodges, you couldn't top that. Well in San Francisco we outdrew a Barnum & Bailey so that'll tell you.

MR: And he would put you in different combinations?

FP: Yeah. Different sets, and some of the night were unbelievable that we didn't record. And we said why didn't we record that one you know? And many, many nights, these players were on you know and they were phenomenal. They were the best, and like certain nights it was just, wow. It was unbelievable.

MR: Just take off, huh?

FP: I'd call that the greatest show on earth.

MR: Well they did record one particular night, where you played the solo on "Perdido" which has followed you around.

FP: Yeah that was a good one. That came off, we had a concert at, not the Island, the Mosque Theater in Newark at eight o'clock, and at twelve o'clock we went to Carnegie Hall in New York, and that's when it was made, in 1947. We played it and everybody was relaxed and it just came off. It was wonderful you know at the time, and we didn't think anything of it. And then when the record — all the disc jockeys started playing it. And it was quite a thing. It sold a million albums. For an instrumental, that's great. And it was just great. We had a good rhythm section there. Jo Jones, Hank Jones, Ray Brown.

MR: How can you go wrong with those guys behind you?

FP: Barney Kessel. It was just a great rhythm section, a great bunch of guys, and it happened. It was one of the nights it came off.

MR: Illinois had almost a similar type thing with "Flying Home" you know? It's interesting, those certain moments that happen to get caught. I guess radio was a huge part of —

FP: Radio was the only thing then. There was no television you know. Every town you went to they played them, you'd make interviews, and it was, radio was the whole thing. Not like today. Television knocked us out of the box.

MR: Yeah. Other people have said that.

FP: You want to know why?

MR: Yes I do.

FP: My opinion. 'Cause we didn't move around as much as these people, jumping up in the air, coming out of the earth, coming out of the grave and jumping with the lights. We didn't do that. Oscar Peterson played a hell of a piano you know, but he didn't jump down in the thing, he didn't have the lights flashing. Jacquet could move, I could move, but we didn't have the lights. And these guys came along with the lights and jumping

from the ceilings and all of that, and that what, television is moving pictures, and that's what the people want to see you move. It's moving pictures.

MR: You spent a little time touring with Benny Goodman too.

FP: Yeah.

MR: I'm watching the time too, we'll wrap up here pretty quick.

FP: I've got to make it —

MR: Jerry Dodgion.

FP: Yeah. I saw — I didn't see him he called me before I came here. He's quite a player, Jerry.

MR: Nice guy. He told me to ask you about something. The I-W-S Tour. He made me promise I'd ask.

FP: I-W-S.

MR: You want to talk about that for a moment?

FP: I put it on my horn, on my saxophone case, I-W-S. Well he told you to say that. Well Benny used to pick on everybody you know. He picked on everybody but me, let's put it that way. And I-W-S was "I Won't Snap." I don't care what you say, I won't snap you know. And when people used to get mad at him, I'd go, "I-W-S." He'd go, "Okay." That's where that came from. I won't snap. Which I did one time. No I didn't snap, but Benny used to pick on everybody you know. So I got fed up. I went in his dressing room one time and I said, "Look, Pops, what are you putting down?" I said, "You're the best clarinet player in the world. You played Carnegie Hall, you played Symphony Hall, you played all over, the only place you haven't played is the moon." And his answer was — And I said, "Go on and play your clarinet. You play better than anybody." And his answer was, "You know, Pops, you're right." And since that time he went out and played and he played better than he ever played ever in his life. His wife, John Hammond came over, and said, "I never heard him play like that." He was like a baby, he needed a little —

MR: Wow. He just needed someone to tell him—

FP: He needed someone to tell him. He was picking on every — which I told him the truth you know. He was the best clarinet player. He played all over. But he was picking on things. He had some kind of a complex I think. I said, "Just go out and play your clarinet. You've been all over the world, you haven't played on the moon, that's the only place." I said, "Go out and play your clarinet." He goes, "You know Pops, you're right." And that straightened him out. And he could play. Right after that, everybody was astounded. It just woke him up like.

MR: Wow. Maybe you should have gone into therapy and done that for a few other fellas.

FP: But he did pick on everybody. But he got straightened out. I played golf with him, I went fishing with him and all that. He was like a big baby. He had to have things his way, which is okay you know, but if he sees something, he'd pick, pick, pick. Unnecessary you know.

MR: Have you ever had occasion to play much with Joe Williams?

FP: No, not too much.

MR: Not too much.

FP: We played a couple of times together at a club in Florida. Oh we had a ball. Joe can swing. Yeah I did a couple of things with Joe.

MR: I know you've stood beside Lester Young a few times.

FP: Hmmm?

MR: Lester Young?

FP: Oh yeah. He was my, well he wouldn't ride with no one but me driving the car. He'd sit in the back. Oscar was in the front. And Norman would say at the beginning of the tour, he says, "Prez, who you riding with?" He says, "You know who my bitch is, Lady Flip." He wouldn't drive with nobody. And we got along great. I used to fix his horn and all that. But he was wonderful. He never bothered anybody and he just had his own way of doing things. We got along great. Great player. But I knew Lester before Jazz at the Philharmonic. I met him when he left Count Basie in 1938, '39 something like that. And he was in New York and he did a couple of gigs with us with Frankie Newton see? I was playing clarinet, and it was Lester and Pete Brown. But I knew him before that. And he was big and strong you know and he used to hold his horn like this. And we got along then. But with the Jazz at the Philharmonic, we were closer. And we had many good times. Good player. I loved him.

MR: What's in the immediate future for you. Any traveling? Travel plans?

FP: I just take the things they make me comfortable on. I had a little mishap as you know, but those things happen. And I still like to play but I can't make the one-nighters anymore, you know it's kind of rough, one after another you know.

MR: You've been down here in Florida—

FP: Yeah, I came down here in 1957, '58, '57. Almost 30 years, 29 years. Is it 39? 39. Wow. Boy that's a long time. When I came down here there was nothing here. This was all swamps. It was beautiful. It was beautiful. It was like a fishing village, it was great. Now it's getting like New York.

MR: You get to New York much?

FP: I get there once in a while, in fact I'm going in May, May 9th to play, I think Lionel Hampton's going to be on it. And Dick Hyman.

MR: Good people. Well this has —

FP: I just kind of cool it, you know?

MR: Well I think you've paid your dues.

FP: I think I did. I think I did, yeah.

MR: Well it's been fascinating talking with you.

FP: In fact I played, my final saying, I played with the greatest musicians in the world, I think, the greatest. All the best. And I did come up in the greatest era of music the United States ever had. And I'm glad I was part of it you know. It was the greatest era I think. If you remember that era.

MR: It's quite a gift to the whole world.

FP: That's right. I'm glad I was a part of it. I'll drink to that.

MR: I'll drink to that. Double. Well thanks for coming over and fitting us into your busy schedule here, and it's been a real pleasure.

FP: Thank you.

MR: So on behalf of Hamilton College, I hope your gig goes well tonight.

FP: It's a wonderful college, it looks great.

MR: Yup.

FP: Is this mine?

MR: Maybe we can have you up there sometime.